Why Flock Cameras Are Facing Backlash

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AI Executive Summary

1. Core Thesis The episode examines the growing tension between the adoption of advanced AI-powered license plate reader technology by law enforcement and corporate entities versus public privacy concerns and regulatory backlash. While proponents like Flock CEO Garrett Langley argue these automated systems are essential tools for solving crimes—from homicides to package thefts—with minimal warrant requirements, critics and privacy advocates contend that the aggregation of vehicle data creates a "surveillance state," enabling profiling and potential stalking without sufficient oversight or transparency. The core thesis is that Flock's technology continues to expand its market despite high-profile protests and cancellations in local governments, signaling a broader conflict between corporate surveillance capitalism and individual civil liberties.

2. Key Arguments & Data

3. **Technology Capabilities:** Flock Safety (ALPR/AI cameras) captures billions of vehicle photos monthly; it records make, model, color, dent, and accessories (e.g., gun racks, bumper stickers) beyond just license plates. AI allows searches based on partial data (e.g., "white pickup truck") without a warrant in many jurisdictions.
4. **Crime Solving Claims:** Flock claims to have assisted in solving one million arrests last year. It played a key role in tracking down the Brown University shooting suspect by flagging license plate switches and searching via vehicle characteristics.
5. **Privacy & Civil Liberties Concerns:**
    - Critics argue the technology aggregates life details (work, school runs, religious affiliations) without meeting original legal expectations of privacy.
    - Incidents include police officers allegedly stalking ex-partners using Flock data, and reports that Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) utilizes these databases.
    - Legal stance: Courts ruled drivers do not have a "reasonable expectation of privacy" when driving in public. Privacy groups

(ACLU, EFF) argue the law lags behind technology's aggregative power.

6. **Corporate vs. Backlash Metrics:**
    - **Adoption:** 12,000 customers, deployed in 6,000 communities across 49 states. Surveillance drones are reported as the fastest-growing product line.
    - **Resistance:** At least 50 cities/counties have canceled contracts or deactivated cameras since early last year (e.g., Lockhart, Texas). Flock CEO admitted reducing data retention from 30 days to 7 days and implementing suspicious activity detection tools.
    - **Tracking:** "DeFlock" crowdsourced map tracks ~130,000 ALPRs; ~82% are owned by Flock Safety.

7. **Legal & Political Context:** President Trump noted the technology is under federal study. Vandalism of cameras has become a tactic (though resulting in felony charges in some cases). Lawsuits are pending challenging the constitutionality of searches based on aggregated data.

8. Actionable Takeaways

9. **Monitor Local Infrastructure:** Use tools like "DeFlock," "Flock Hopper," or "Have I Been Flocked" to map ALPR locations and check if your vehicle has been searched in Flock’s database.
10. **Support Privacy Advocacy:** Participate in movements like the "National Week of Action Against ALPRs." Support groups such as ACLU or EFF that are litigating against warrantless surveillance aggregations.
11. **Review Local Government Decisions:** Stay informed on city council votes regarding surveillance contracts (e.g., recent Lockhart, Texas rejection) and advocate for bans or data retention limits at the municipal level.
12. **Assess Personal Data Risk:** Be aware of the "aggregative" nature of driving data; consider the implications of driving frequently in areas with AI cameras for profiling by federal or private entities.

Full Transcript

Hey, it's Ryan. Our colleague Imani Moise is here to guest host today's episode. Here it is. Last night, protesters in Atlanta rallied against the New Street surveillance technology. Flop cameras. Demonstrations like this one are happening across the U.S. this week. When I say block, you say off. Block! Off! This company really has become a lightning rod. It's become such a focal point for opposition. Our colleague Chris Marr was there in Atlanta, reporting on the backlash to these subtle little cameras. They're very inconspicuous initially, but once you start seeing them, you'll see them pretty frequently. Block cameras are essentially the next generation of traffic light cameras. With one big difference, their abilities are supercharged by artificial intelligence. Supporters say flock cameras have helped police keep communities safe. They say these are extremely powerful tools that help them solve crimes. All kinds of crimes from, you know, car thefts to missing persons cases to violent crimes, robberies, homicides. And they're highly effective.

Solving homicides and robberies sounds like a good thing, but you mentioned that there are nationwide protests against flock right now. What is the central concern that people are voicing about the technology? So mostly it's privacy concerns and that these cameras are starting to enable what people call a surveillance state. You know, I think people are becoming aware of how powerful these technologies are and they're starting to question how much do they want them in society and in their lives. and how transparent the people want their lives to be to organizations, whether it's a corporation or the government or the police department. Welcome to The Journal, our show about money, business, and power. I'm Imani Moise. It's Thursday, August 20th. Coming up on the show, PLOCK's AI cameras are leading to arrests and backlash. PLOCK Safety, the company behind the cameras, has been around for almost a decade.

It was co-founded by a man named Garrett Langley. See, I live in a city called Atlanta, and I was frustrated. Crime felt too easy to get away with. That's Langley giving a TED talk earlier this year. Langley, an electrical engineer by training, was fed up with crime happening in his own

neighborhood. Here's Chris again. He was seeing break-ins to houses and cars, and he said the next day the police would show up and sort of shrug their shoulders and say, there's not much we can do. You know, we don't know who did this and we don't have leads. And he said, I'm going to do something about this. So I did what engineers did. I built a license plate reading camera. It sounds simple. But I called two of my best friends from Georgia Tech and we built this camera. Langley set up that camera near his home. And about two months later, he said another wave of breakings happened. This time they had a camera and they were able to see that.

The previous night, there had only been one car traveling through the neighborhood. They gave the information to the police, and they put out a bolo behind the lookout for this car, and they found it, and they found the stolen materials. We solved our first crime, and that was the beginning of Flock. At first, Flock customers were mostly homeowners associations and neighborhoods. But as AI became more advanced, so did Flock's products. And that's made the cameras more appealing to more customers. like retailers, schools, and even police departments. They're in about 6,000 communities, and today they have 12,000 customers. Block cameras are now in 49 states in the U.S. You can often find them at intersections, hovering above the street on a metal pole. One of the tell-tale signs that you're looking at a block camera is that it has a solar panel attached to it. Block cameras are part of a whole category called ALPRs, or Automated License Plate Readers.

But Flock has pretty much become the face of these types of cameras. What makes these cameras different from traffic-like cameras? Some of the other cameras that we've gotten used to seeing out on the street. Yeah, it's true. I mean, these cameras are different because they're capturing every single vehicle and they're license plate trackers, technically, but they really do capture more than just license plates. They're capturing the make and model of the car, the color, a bumper sticker, whether it has a dent or ski rack or a bicycle or gun rack. Any kind of identifying markers are also captured by these cameras. Glock says its cameras take billions of photos of cars each month, and all of them are uploaded to a database that clients can search through. These AI tools make it very searchable very easily. It can also be

searched across state lines if the local jurisdiction opts into that. And most searches, you know, don't require a warrant.

Recently, Chris got a demo from a flock executive on how the camera's NAI worked together. He showed how he could do a search without a license plate or full license plate, and just using some characteristics of a car like a white pickup truck was the actual search he did. The executive typed the words white pickup truck into flock software system. Then he added a filter for an exact time and location. They zeroed in on one car in particular. This is what privacy advocates and critics are concerned about. Think of all the places you may have driven over the last two weeks. What kind of picture would be painted of who you are? You can sort of start to piece together somebody's life, I think. You know, you can tell maybe where they go to work, if they're dropping their kids off at school, who they're associating with, their religious affiliation. All sorts of things can start to be inferred that way. So, Chris, what do you think Flock knows about you based on where you've been driving recently? You know, that's such a good question. I don't know. It might know how many times I go to the giant eagle to grocery store or to the gym.

To the wah-wah? Yeah. Well, we have sheets out here, so. Even better. Yeah. All this tracking has helped police solve some serious high-profile crimes. We're interrupting regular programming with an update on the mass shooting at Brown University in Providence, Rhode Island. In December, a suspect shot and killed two Brown University students and an MIT professor. At first, police were unable to locate the suspect's vehicle. Then the tech company Flock was able to provide advanced search features to find the car and flag that the plates had been switched. Police were then able to track the car based on its make and model and find the suspect. And you can imagine how this tech would be helpful to police in other cases too. Typically, eyewitnesses aren't remembering license plate numbers. They're recalling basic details what the car looked like if it had a bumper sticker. Flock says the cameras led to one million arrests just last year.

But there have also been mistakes, and police have come to the wrong conclusions based on flock data, like in Denver last year. Denver woman says that she was wrongly accused of a crime after police told her they

tracked her car using flock cameras. Police showed up at the woman's house, saying they had photos of her car in the area where a package was stolen. But it wasn't her car. It just happened to look a lot like it. Lucky for her, she was able to prove her innocence using dash cam footage from her own car. In other cases, the data being collected by Flock cameras aren't just behind police mistakes, but purposeful misuse. This week, three Georgia police officers were added to a growing list of cops accused of misusing the camera technology to allegedly stalk citizens, including ex-wives and girlfriends. There are also concerns that Flock's database is being used by immigration and customs enforcement, or ICE. Flock says it does not have any contracts with the Department of Homeland Security.

It does work with other federal agencies. And there have been cases where cities have found that immigration searches have been done into their systems. Flock said how clients use camera data is up to them. As evidence of mistakes and misuse proliferate, so do the cameras and the backlash. That's next. A big question you might have about Flock cameras given all the data they're collecting is, are these cameras even legal? To get into the legal side of this, the courts have ruled that people and drivers don't have a reasonable expectation of privacy when they're out in public. Legal experts told Chris, Flock doesn't violate privacy rights or Fourth Amendment protections against unreasonable searches. But the groups like the ACLU, the Electronic Frontier Foundation, other privacy advocates, both on the left and the right side, do say that once you start Using the technology to aggregate things and come up with searchable databases, you're really going far beyond what the laws originally intended or considered. More lawsuits are pending, with some plaintiffs arguing the law just hasn't caught up with the technology yet. In the meantime, some people are taking the matter into their own hands and vandalizing cameras. People shooting cameras with shotguns, covering them with stickers.

cutting them down with saws. So it really has stirred some strong emotions. Online videos promoting destruction of the cameras have gone viral. If you see these and you could do something about them, move them. If they're in your neighborhood, get rid of them. Do whatever you can to get rid of these. Like we're headed towards a mass surveillance nanny police state. Some vandalism cases have resulted in felony charges, but there are also

more law abiding approaches. Groups like Deflock are fighting data with data. Chris spoke with his founder, a software engineer named Will Freeman. He started spotting these cameras on a cross-country trip from the West Coast to Huntsville, Alabama, where he's from, and started putting together this kind of crowdsourced map, and it grew into this...

Pretty detailed map and website, and they're tracking about 130,000 ALPRs or automated license plate readers. About 82% of those are owned by Flock Safety. DeFlock is behind many of this week's protests, part of what they're calling a national week of action against ALPRs. There are also websites called Flock Hopper and Have I Been Flocked, where citizens can see where ALPRs have been set up, and if their vehicle has been looked up by police in Flock's database. Flock CEO Langley said he respects criticism and legal challenges from privacy groups. The pushback has led some communities to limit the tech in their area. At least 50 cities and counties have canceled flock contracts or deactivated cameras since early last year. And some states have changed regulations to address how long flock data can be stored, shared or accessed. And these communities span the political spectrum. Here's testimony from a town hall in right-leaning Lockhart, Texas.

Frankly, I don't think anyone in this town wants to be looking over their shoulder constantly wondering who might be watching them. If you trade away all of your privacy to gain security, you end up with neither. What is the need for it? We do not need them. We don't need them at the cost of violating everybody's rights. Lockhart City Council ultimately decided to reject proposals to enter contracts with Flock. I'd like to make a motion to not to go forward with the Flock cameras. Due to the community outpour of how negative they can impact our community. Motion passes 6-1. Okay. So we will not proceed. Earlier this week, President Trump joined the debate, saying that Flock is, quote, being studied right now by the federal government. You know, you have pros and cons, right? It's being studied right now. We'll have an answer sort of as to our views on it over the next couple of weeks.

And all of that attention is putting pressure on the company. In a recent interview with CBS, Flock CEO Langley addressed how Flock has been

used by police officers to stalk ex-partners. Can you put yourself in those women's shoes? No, it's horrible and I apologize. Did you take enough responsibility soon enough? I think hindsight is a brutal tool. Of course, we could have done more earlier and we listen and we learn and we'll continue to move forward. Last week, the company announced that it would cut the default amount of time flock data is stored from 30 days down to 7. And they initiated new safeguards to address police misuse. They're saying by the end of the year, police departments will have to have this tool that detects suspicious activity and can even shut down the system if it detects something that's amiss. Have those changes satisfied critics so far? No, not at all. So the critics I've talked to has said that they see this as a victory. They see this as flock being on the defensive and they want to keep pushing. I mean, they especially want to win in the courts, but they also want to win in the court of public opinion as well. And that's, I think, why these protests are happening this week. Does it seem like the backlash is slowing down the company's growth at all? Not that I've seen so far. They continue to barrel forward from everything I can see and from talking to the CEO. You know, the adoption is growing quickly.

There have been cities that have canceled or deactivated their flock cameras. But the company says the number that are adopting the cameras and signing new contracts is far outpacing that. Langley recently said in a podcast that another flock product, surveillance drones, had become the company's fastest growing business. The image you painted with people actually shooting these cameras. It reminds me of the Industrial Revolution when we saw the Luddites breaking into factories and destroying the machines. But then you fast forward to today and factories still exist, automation still exists. Do you see this as growing pains or is something else going on here? I do see this as like a sign of things to come as people grapple with AI in particular and surveillance technology. It's very hard to see it going away as it is with other technologies that get developed.

So I'm really interested to see where this goes over the next few months because the clashes seem to be so intense at the moment and it does seem to be tracking along the same lines as fights over data centers and AI generally, I think it's just such an interesting time where we have this, you know, still really fairly new technology that's so pervasive so suddenly and

then we have people across the country responding to it so strongly. For now, the question remains. How much of our privacy do we want to give up? Or do we want to put innocent people's information at risk to solve certain crimes? That's all for today, Thursday, August 20th. The journal is a co-production of Spotify and The Wall Street Journal. Additional reporting in this episode by Victoria Albert. Thanks for listening. See you tomorrow.